Stolen Valor

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/42483750.

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Teen And Up Audiences

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No Archive Warnings Apply

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

Character:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Randor (He-Man), Marlena (He-Man), He-Man | Adam, Glimmer (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra)

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by ResFlower

Summary

She knocks on the apartment door that belongs to her brother, fully ready to arrange her face into a disappointed scowl but when the door opens, Adam's broad frame is nowhere to be found.

Instead, Adora has to lower her gaze to find a stunning woman wearing shorts and a vintage t-shirt that is somehow both baggy and still looks great on her.

The brunette eyes Adora up and down, a devastating smile crossing her lips as she does so. Adora stares back, mouth open to say something but no sound comes out.

"Adam there's a hot blonde at the door . . . is this one of the strippers you thought about marrying?" She calls into the house. She leans against the door frame and the t-shirt collar dips, revealing a delicate shoulder. "Because given new information, can't blame you for considering it."

Adora can feel the blush rushing up her face and adds strip clubs and potentially marrying strippers to the list of things she has to talk to her brother about.

OR

Adora visits her brother, worried that he rushed into marriage just like all his military friends. What happens when his wife seems to be her perfect girl? Military Marriage AU.

Notes

See the end of the work for notes

"Adam did *what*?" Adora can't help the way she holds her hand up to her head and groans. They're huddled around the kitchen counter. Adora had just gotten off work and hadn't been expecting to hear that her brother got married in secret.

Marlena points at her daughter looking at her husband with exasperated eyes. "Yes! See Adora has the right reaction here!" She stands up tall, anger flashing in her eyes. "I shouldn't have to find out my only son got married because he got advertisements for honeymoon vacation packages!"

Randor eyes the two women standing across from the countertop. "He probably has his reasons. He's been through a lot these last two years. Grown-up. Maybe it's matured him?" He offers weakly with a grimace.

"For all we know he married this woman to get out of the barracks!" Marlena huffs. "We know he's been complaining about it nonstop for the last two years."

"I don't think he would do something that extreme Marlena." He runs a hand over his beard, a few silver hairs standing out from the brown. "Maybe it was love at first sight? We should just trust his judgment."

His wife narrows her eyes on him. "Randor, our son has been in the military and clearly not meditating on his life decisions. He just married a girl who just met. He couldn't even tell me her last name!"

"Well, it might be Grayskull now." He points out with a cheeky grin, leaning back in his chair.

Marlena rolls her eyes. "You never take anything seriously, Randor." She looks at Adora, a pleading expression crossing her gaze. "Can you please go visit him? Make sure he's okay?"

Adora sighs. "Mom, I mean this is a lot, but I can't just go and confront Adam about why he got married." She bites her lip to keep her feelings to herself.

She can't believe Adam got married and didn't even tell her. They hadn't been as close since he joined the military but still, he was her twin. For so long, it was him and her through thick and thin. She at least expected a heads up, not to hear it from her *mom*.

"You've been meaning to go visit him anyway. And he's already moved in with his *wife*." Marlena looks a little green when she says it. "I thought you wanted to tell him about going to FBI in person?"

"I got into FBI I don't know if I'm going yet." She gently corrects. Adora shifts her weight, bending one of her knees. She does want to tell Adam about her acceptance and figure out what the hell he's thinking, marrying a random woman. And why he didn't talk to her about it. "Fine. I'll see if I can get some time off in the upcoming weeks and I'll visit him."

Marlena pulls her into a hug. "Thank you, dear. I worry about him."

Adora rolls her eyes good-naturedly. It's always been like that. Adam is the wild and free child while Adora has always been a bit more reserved. "I know. But I'm not going to do anything to that poor girl. She's already suffering having to be married to Adam." She cracks, mainly looking at her dad. He doesn't disappoint, laughing at her joke.

Marlena rolls her eyes. "I don't want you to do anything to her. I just want to make sure your brother hasn't lost his damn mind."

"Language mother!" She gapes at her mom, pretending to be scandalized.

Randor laughs loudly, it practically shakes the room. "Adora has a point, you know." He says with twinkling eyes. He pulls Marlena

close holding her with more gentleness than his hulking mass would suggest. Marlena groans but smiles anyway.

Her flight was stuffy and crowded, she's glad it was a short one—it's only two hours between Eternia and the FZ base. She realizes pretty quickly that Adam's new apartment isn't on base at all, instead in the nearby town of Erelandia, sitting between the base and FZ.

The apartment complex looks nice. A lot of the people walking around seem to be either college kids or young families. She knocks on the apartment door that belongs to her brother, fully ready to arrange her face into a disappointed scowl but when the door opens, Adam's broad frame is nowhere to be found.

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"I wasn't going to marry a stripper . . ." He protests. His voice doesn't sound convincing which is worrisome in itself. Adora can hear him closer as he talked to the woman. "My basket of fresh bread, can you not block the door?" He sounds some mix of annoyed and teasing that reminds her of when Adora gets on his last nerve.

The woman rolls her eyes. "That's not even cute Adam. And you're a fucking giant you can see past me." She waves dismissively but she doesn't move her eyes from Adora.

She sees Adam pop up behind the beautiful shorter girl. "Adora!" He says cheerily, moving past the girl to pull her into a big hug. "I missed you so much. What are you doing up here?" He doesnt let go squeezing her tight.

She hugs him back but then takes a step back so she can stare at him. "Adam, come on." She eyes him and he has the nerve to still look confused.

"So that's a no on the stripper , then?" The woman he refers to as Cat asks again with a hint of disappointment.

Adam turns green and makes a gagging noise. "This is my twin sister. Gross, Cat!" He stands so that Adora and he are side-by-side and gestures between them.

The brunette smirks looking between them. "Absolutely not. Y our face doesn't look like hers." She then looks at Adora again. "Y eah, they are *decidedly* different."

Her smile turns a little less feral as she holds out her hand. "Hi, I'm Catra. Adam's...wife." She introduces herself curtly . Adora's stomach plummets at the confirmation.

She reaches out and shakes Catra's hand, wondering how her handshake is so sure while her hand is so soft. "Adora." She manages to spit out. "I'm his older sister ."

"It was *three minutes*." Adam gripes but there' s no heat to it. Hell probably be protesting those three minutes for the rest of his life.

Adora shoves her elbow into his ribs. "W ell clearly, the three extra minutes did nothing to help with your frontal lobe. Mom sent me."

Adam groans, stomping back from whence he came. "Ugh, mom won't let me do anything! I'm a grown man!"

Catra cackles at that. "You're really crying about what your mom *lets* you do at twenty years old?"

He glares at her, bumping her out of the way as he gets into the apartment. "Shut up, I'm sensitive and care about my mother's opinions on things." He turns to his sister. "So where are you staying while you're here?" Adam asks as he invites Adora in.

She eyes him warily. "I mean it's a two-bedroom apartment, right? I figured I'd take the guest room." She shrugs. "My luggage is in the car still."

She watches as Adam and Catra lock eyes, doing that silent communication thing that couples do sometimes, although this seems more violent than what she's seen before. When they break their stare, they both turn to look at her.

"We don't really sleep in the same bed," Catra explains. "He snores too much for that." She tacks on shooting him a grin.

"Hey! It's *not* that bad." Adam's ears turn red.

"Sorry pretty boy, I can hear you from the other side of the apartment." She teases with a roll of her eyes.

Adora furrows her brow but nods. That seems a bit odd for newlyweds, but she knows Adam snores like a train. Besides, what does she know about being married? "So, I guess I can bunk up with Adam?" Suddenly a doubt creeps into her head. "Unless I'd be imposing too much, I know you're newly married and all—"

Catra shakes her head, reaching out to put a hand on Adora's shoulder. "No, of course not! Adam's family is always welcome." She gives her a soft smile. "I mean, if you get tired of the snoring maybe you could bunk up with *me* instead." She seems to get closer.

Adora laughs at the joke.

Adam rolls his eyes, hip-checking Catra which makes her hand fall away from Adora's shoulder. "Not helpful, Catra."

She turns to face her sister-in-law, and she's struck by the realization that her eyes are two different colors. Whatever she was going to say was abandoned in favor of marveling at the difference between the blue eye and the hazel one.

"Heterochromia." She offers when she notices Adora's blatant stare. Her lips twitch as if she's going to say something else, but she doesn't.

Adora can feel her face heat at being caught. "I'm sorry, I wasn't trying to make you feel uncomfortable. I lost my train of thought." She offers meekly. She did lose her train of thought, if only because Catra is so gorgeous. "Can I use the bathroom? It was a long flight."

Catra nods, an amused smile gracing her lips as she points Adora in the direction of the bathroom. She quickly walks away her heart hammering in her ears.

"This is an emergency." She whispers having called both Glimmer and Bow. She turned on the extractor so sound wouldn't carry out of the bathroom, but you can never be too careful. "I'm at Adam's apartment."

"Well, you were supposed to get there just now, how can there already be an emergency?" Glimmer wonders aloud.

"His wife is so fucking hot I sounded like such an idiot talking to her." She groans. It's not that she expected Adam to not have a pretty wife. She knows some women are into that kind of thing, Adam never had trouble finding partners, but she didn't imagine she would be attracted to whoever Adam married.

"Well, it can't be that bad, can it?" Bow, ever the optimist, adds his two cents.

"I think the only complete sentence I managed was to ask for the bathroom." She can hear the collective wince on the other end of the line.

"Well, that's not great. Have you talked to Adam yet?" Bow probes gently.

"No, I haven't and what am I supposed to do about that." She frets. "Shit, *I'd* marry her in two weeks too if given the option, how am I supposed to tell *him* that he fucked up?" She hisses into her phone.

"Okay, but how hot?" Glimmer asks eagerly. "You're making her sound out of this world and like, I need to know what we are dealing with."

Bow makes a disappointed noise. "That's not the point Glimmer." There's a slight pause. "But you know, sending a picture would be a good idea."

Adora rolls her eyes. This isn't getting anywhere. She's probably taking too long in the bathroom anyway. "Alright, I'm gonna go now."

"Send pictures!" Glimmer repeats as she hangs up.

The rest of the afternoon is spent chatting~~-~~but really, mostly listening~~-~~to the newlyweds. She finds out they met through a mutual friend that she vaguely remembers and that it was love at first sight. Catra seems kind of nauseated by that, but Adora is starting to think Catra just isn't an affectionate person, at least in public.

The apartment itself is clean and put together. It feels homier than Bow and Glimmer's dorm up in BMU. The living area is cozy, blankets litter every surface and there is a shelf of books that Adora

wants to look at before she leaves. She thinks that most of the stylistic choices are Catra's, mostly soft greens and slate grays.

Adora sits on the couch next to Catra and Adam sits on the big recliner across from them that he moved so they could chat more comfortably. It feels like every time she glances at Catra from the corner of her eye, her sister-in-law is closer than before.

"I'm going to cook some dinner. Catra you can take care of my sister?" Adam asks as he gets up from his chair.

She raises an eyebrow at him. "I can *more* than take care of Adora." Her voice drops to a sultry rasp and Adora has to stop herself from snapping her head in the brunette's direction.

Adam narrows his eyes at her. "Behave, *wife*." He says sternly.

Adora bristles at that. "You should be nicer to Catra."

Adam stares, almost as if he forgot that Adora could hear their conversation. "Yeah sorry, I didn't mean anything by it. Let me know if you need anything." He walks away but not without giving Catra another testy look that doesn't sit right with Adora. She doesnt think Adam would ever be bad to a partner, but she will kick his ass if it turns out he is.

Catra doesn't seem bothered though as she immediately turns to face Adora. "So, what do you do?"

Adora grabs one of the green pillows, holding it to her chest as she turns to look at Catra. She looks so relaxed and soft leaning against the couch, amused eyes on Adora. It makes her feel a bit exposed.

"I'm working a receptionist job right now. I took a gap year that kind of became two." She bites her lip. She feels a bit self-conscious about not going straight to college like all her friends. "But I finally got into school, and I'll be starting in the fall."

Catra brightens at that. "I'm transferring universities in the fall. I got into the engineering program at FIU." She looks at Adora curiously. "What are you studying?"

"I'm thinking about doing the vet tech program." She thinks about telling Catra that she was accepted in FIU too, but she wants to tell Adam first. "That's convenient though, you're so close to campus from here."

Catra nods. "Yeah, I mean it's a decent commute for both of us which is why we picked this apartment."

Adora feels dumb for not having considered that. "Oh, that makes sense." She has to make a conscious effort to stop tugging on a loose thread she found on the edge of the pillow.

Catra picks her legs up onto the couch and Adora makes her most valiant effort at looking anywhere except there. "Yeah, I wasn't even sure if I'd be able to go but now, I'm all set." She reaches out and gently touches Adora's shoulder. "What made you think about vet school?

"As cliché as it sounds, I volunteered at an animal shelter. It's where I got all my volunteer hours in high school. I didn't really think about it as a career option until I kept volunteering and started helping with some basic first aid there." The animal shelter made her feel centered and fulfilled.

She'd really struggled with figuring out what she wanted to do, and she ended up paralyzed by indecision. She'd finally gotten past that, but it still stings to think about it.

Catra smiles. "That's really cool. I've always wanted a cat."

Adora leans forward and starts gesturing as she talks. "Well, cats are really cool, in the shelter we have this long-haired—"

"Dinner's ready!" Adam bellows from the kitchen.

An annoyed look crosses Catra's face. "Let's go eat and you can tell me about the cute shelter cats."

Adora nods, her stomach sitting heavy with the realization that for a moment she'd forgotten who she was speaking with.

When she finally manages to corner Adam after everyone decides to go to sleep, he puts his hand up as if in surrender. "I know what you're going to say." He starts haltingly.

"Adam." She remains unimpressed. She sits down on the bed and stares at him.

"But hear me out first!" He insists.

"*Adam*."

"Look I know it's fast, but I know what I want. And Catra did too. We are really secure in our marriage and it's working for us. We've been married for almost a month with no major issues. Can't you be happy for me?" He pleads, blue eyes shining.

"You're sure about this?" Adora tries. "It's a short time to be sure about something like this. You're *twenty*." She can't wrap her head around it. She barely felt fit to pick a career, must less a person to spend her whole life with.

"So? Almost all my military buddies are married. It isn't weird here." He defends hotly.

"We're just worried, Adam." Adora bit her lip. "And you didn't even tell me you got married. I know things have been different since you moved but this is important."

His face melts and he pulls her into a hug tugging her off the bed. "Oh Dor. It's not that at all. Everything was kind of a whirlwind. And I didn't want to disappoint you. Or mom."

"Well, I'm mostly just fucking sad that I didn't even get to be with you for your wedding. And mom is freaked about the whole thing, but she's going to be sad too once she calms down."

He looks guilty, which makes his boyish face look odd now that he's grown almost as big as Randor. "I'm sorry. Really. I didn't think about it like that."

Adora takes a deep breath. "It's fine. I um—" She tries to fight the blush rushing to her face. "I can see why you love her."

Adam smiles more freely. "Yeah, Catra's a great person. It's nice having her around." Not exactly a ringing endorsement of true love but she knows that Adam feels love and sexual desire differently than she does.

She fixes her sights on him. "But seriously. How did it happen this quickly? You're demiromantic!" It's one of the things that has been bugging her since she found out and one of the reasons why she was so worried that Adam might have rushed into things.

He rolls his eyes. "Sometimes you just know, Adora. Someday, you'll understand." She rolls her eyes at his silly platitude. Meanwhile, he looks at the bedroom door. "And could you keep it quiet? Catra doesn't know about that."

Adora stares at him, eyebrows raised. "Why not? Is she one of those straight girls that are supportive of queer folks until she actually has to interact with them?" She didn't get that vibe from talking to Catra, but they'd only just met.

Adam snorts. "Trust me, Catra is not that type of person." He assures with a small laugh. "She's *beyond* supportive of the LGBT plus community you could say." He sighs and purses his lips. "You know I've always felt complicated about my identity. It just hasn't come up organically and I just want to figure that out on my own."

Adora nods. She can remember Adam crying and telling her about how different he felt when he simply wasn't interested in girls the same way his teammates were in high school, or even the way Adora was. He'd started coming to terms with being on the ace spectrum when he was shipped off to Bootcamp.

"Well, I obviously won't tell her. But that seems like something you should be able to trust the woman you married." She points out. "That's kind of the point of marriage, isn't it?" Adora hasn't even thought of the idea of marriage as more than an incredibly distant milestone that could be good to reach, but whenever she does think of it, it's with someone she would trust with everything.

"I understand that you're skeptical. But the important thing is that Catra and I are fine, and we won't be hurting each other alright? You can report back to mom and tell her that I'm fine." He gives her a small smile. "So, can we just drop it so we can enjoy the time you're here? You haven't come up to visit me in forever."

Adora punches his shoulder. "Fine, I'll leave it alone for now. And if your happy, I'm happy."

He ruffles her hair despite her protest. "That's what I like to hear! Grayskull twins bunking up and hanging out just like old times."

She can't help but smile at his exuberance. Even though they call regularly, she really did miss her brother.

The next morning once she finally wakes up, she notices that Adam isn't there anymore. She gets ready and finds that Catra is already up and brewing coffee.

"Hey, hotshot. Do you like eggs?" She calls out easily, making her way to the fridge. Adora sits down at the counter and watches Catra walk back and forth amongst the appliances clearly cooking something. Catra stops right in front of Adora and reaches out, flicking her forehead. "Hey, Grayskull. Eggs?"

"Huh?" She blinks, trying her best not to look down at the crop top Catra has decided to wear today. She finally remembers the question. "Yes, I eat pretty much everything."

Catra scoffs, her hand trailing up and touching a loose tendril of hair on Adora's head. She can feel her heart sputter as Catra twirls it and then pushes it behind her ear. "Seems like a family thing then." She comments offhand before she turns back to the stove, leaving Adora with a view of her long legs and toned backside.

Adora notices that multiple burners are on at once. "What are you making?"

"*Huevos rancheros*. You're going to lose your mind when you try this, princess." She hums happily and sways as she cooks. Adora has to bite her lip to keep from cooing at how cute she looks. "Adam got called on duty for an emergency shift, he'll probably be gone until tomorrow." She mentions offhand.

Adora wilts a bit at that, she'd been looking forward to spending time together. "That sucks."

Catra hums in agreement. "Yeah, that does suck for him. It happens at least once a month. Who knew the military is terrible at scheduling shit?" She sends Adora a heavy-handed look.

Adora rolls her eyes and smiles at Catra. "Yeah, who knew."

Catra serves the eggs on what looks like big round tortilla chips and brings a plate over. "I figure we should get to know each other, especially since Adam is going to be on base. I'll show you around."

Adora swallows thickly as she grabs her plate. "Yeah, that sounds good."

She watches Catra out of the corner of her because she isn't quite sure how she's supposed to eat the dish in front of her. She watches as Catra picks up the little disk and bites into it with a crunch.

She picks it up and does the same. She closes her eyes, the flavors bursting in her mouth. The crunchiness of the base and the runny egg and the sauce just melded together in a way she'd never really tasted before.

"Fuck, Catra."She wipes her mouth and looks at the other woman. "This is so good. What' s in this?"

Catra stares at her in a focused way that makes Adora feel a bit like she's in trouble. The other woman takes a deep breath then looks at Adora again. "So, you have your corn tortilla, a runny egg, and the secret tomato sauce that I'll take to my grave. Some people like to add refried beans, but Ileave them of f most of the time."She gestures to the kitchen. "Mostly because I'm impatient."

"Really? Icant get the sauce recipe?"Adora pouts genuinely disappointed. She isn't sure she'd be able to recreate the dish, but she'd definitely try .

Catra smirks at her. "Sorry , family only. You'd have to marry me for it."She says loftily .

"So, Adam gets it then?"Adora asks with a raised eyebrow . She feels unreasonably jealous about that.

"Pf ft, no, why would Igive him that."She rolls her eyes.

Adora tilts her head, unsure if she's missing something. "Because you married him?"

"Ah. Iguess you have a point."She picks up her plate and does the same with Adora's which only has a few tortilla crumbs. "So, want me to show you around town?"

"Y eah, that sounds great."She feels her gut flip-flop at the smile that Catra gives her, and she knows she's in trouble.

While she’s getting dressed after breakfast, her phone starts ringing. She rolls her eyes, already guessing who it is.

She picks up the phone. "So? What's she like?" Marlena presses, no greeting for her most beloved daughter.

Adora huffs. "Hi mom, how are you? I'm great, thanks for checking in." She stares at two of her shirts, vaguely thinking about which one might bring out her arms more before deciding that she should stop thinking about that.

"Adora." She says impatiently. "You know I love you with my whole heart, but I need to know if my other child is being swindled by a woman of loose morals."

Adora laughs at that. "No no. First of f, not cool to stereotype mom. Besides, Catra doesn't seem like the type she's..." Adora lets out a quiet sigh. "Very bright. She got into this really competitive engineering program that she's starting in the fall. And she's funny—dad would love her, she's just so *witty*. I think you'd really like her mom."

She waits and waits but her mom doesn't respond.

"Mom?" She asks uncertainly into the phone, as she finally tugs on her white shirt.

Marlena sighs. "I'm glad I don't have any other children for this woman to enchant."

"Mom! I'm not enchanted or whatever!" Adora could feel her blush rising. Why would you even think that?

"Maybe it's genetic," Marlena mutters under her breath. "Well, I suppose what's done is done. You're sure she isn't taking advantage of him?

"Y es, mom."She says absentmindedly as she puts on her shorts. "Look, mom, Ihave to go. Love you, bye!"

"What' s your favorite thing to do out here?"Adora asks as they walk around the small downtown. They'd been to a few of the major landmarks and even drove around the outskirts of the university before deciding to stop here. "Anything you and Adam do together?" She tries.

She wants to know more about Catra, but she brings up Adam to remind herself of why she should want that in the first place. Catra tilts her head before looking around the street. Her whole face brightens as she spots something.

"Come on princess."She grabs Adora' s hand and pulls her with a lot more strength than Adora would expect from someone so small.

"Hey slow down."Adora has to take bigger steps than usual to keep up with Catra's rapid pace.

"No can do, this is the best part of downtown."She stops in front of an ice cream shop. "This place has everything homemade, and they also do fudge. Want to get a cone?"

She looks so hopeful there's no way Adora is going to say no. "I'm game. What do you think is good here?"They walk inside and start making the line.

"I always get the bourbon pecan ice cream with the waf fle cone." She points to the display. "But you can't go wrong with the chocolate or the strawberry. The mint is good too. Honestly, just don't get the neon-colored ones and you should be fine."

Adora nods seriously. "Okay . I'll have strawberry on a waf fle cone."

Catra makes an approving noise. "Good choice. Sugar cones are for wimps."

Adora smiles at the definitive statement. They put in their order with little fuss until they get to the cash register. She swipes Catra's card as she tries to give it to the cashier.

"Nope. This is on me. As a thank you for showing me around."Adora gives the cashier her card.

"No way , give me my card back."Catra stands on her tiptoes but still cant reach Adora' s hand which is held over her head. Catra is dead focused on reaching it and Adora is so amused she doesnt notice how close their faces are until the cashier clears his throat waving Adora's card.

She takes a step back, feeling the blood rush to her face as she grabs the card. "Looks like Iwon this round. W ant to walk while we eat this?"

Catra nods her eyes still narrowed on Adora. "Y ou fight dirty."She accuses but she still walks.

As they walk Adora remembers why she typically doesnt swing for ice cream on first dates. Not that this is a date but getting ice cream on her clothes in front of Catra would be just as embarrassing.

"Why did Iwear a white shirt?"She questions pitifully as she tries to hold the ice cream at a safe distance from her shirt but also in a way that she's able to eat the damn thing. Catra's right that the ice cream is delicious but it's melting way too fast.

Catra laughs at her, which, Adora guesses, is fair. "The shirt looks good,"Catra assures. "And you just need to eat faster ."She says sagely as she wraps her lips around her cone again.

That was ninety percent of the problem~~the~~ distracting way Catra was eating her ice cream cone was keeping Adora from hers. She sighs and takes a deep breath focusing on her cone and not Catra. t' s harder than it looks.

A few more blocks and Adora gives up, dropping what's left of her runny cone into a garbage can. Catra rolls her eyes as she looks at Adora who is pouting, holding out her sticky hands in hopes of saving her clothes.

"You're such a goof," Catra says fondly, and by some miracle she pulls out a stack of napkins from her bag, handing a few to Adora.

"Why do you have that many napkins?" She asks as she wipes down her hands.

"Are you kidding? I saw you eat breakfast this morning, I grabbed them at the ice cream shop. I had a feeling we might need them." She teases.

Adora is about to protest when Catra takes a step closer, running a napkin over the corner of Adora's lip. She feels like she can't breathe with Catra standing so close, her hands gently on Adora's face as she cleans her up.

"There." She says as she takes a step back.

"Thanks." Adora whispers, she doesn't know why. "Let's take a picture to send to Adam." She then blurts out. She still owes Glimmer that picture and this is an easy way to get it.

"Sure." Catra stands next to her looping her hand around her waist, one of her fingers sitting in Adora's belt loop. Catra's thumb skirts a bit of skin that's exposed when she stretches her arm to take the picture and she can hardly breathe.

She quickly snaps the thing and shows it to Catra, guessing she'll want to make sure she looks good in a picture being sent to her husband. Naturally, she does. Adora hasn't seen Catra look anything short of amazing for even a moment the whole time she's been visiting.

"We look good together," Catra observes before looking up at Adora with her gorgeous eyes and making what little brain activity she'd put together just disintegrate like a raccoon foolishly trying to wash cotton candy.

"Yeah." Adora breathes out because they do. They're both smiling brightly, pressed close together looking cozy. If she didn't know any better and she saw that picture, she'd reckon they were dating.

She quickly sends it off to Adam, telling him that they miss him. And then quickly sends the same picture to Glimmer. Immediately, her phone starts vibrating and doesn't stop for thirty straight seconds. She ignores it and the raised eyebrow that Catra sends her way.

"Aren't you going to answer whoever that is?"

She bites her lip. "No. I'd rather hang out with you right now. Be present. I haven't had a vacation in forever." She admits.

She grabs Adora's hand and tugs her along. "Alright then, let me take you to my *real* favorite place." She says with a grin. Adora would happily follow her anywhere.

They end up driving in the car for another twenty minutes until they end up on a deserted park lot that overlooks not only the town but also the military base and part of the university. If you squint you can even see the edges of the ocean, even though that's an hour's drive from where they are.

"When you're in town, sometimes it can feel so small and stifling," Catra explains. "But up here, you have perspective. I know it's just an old parking lot, but the view is unparalleled."

It's close to sunset and the town is bathed in pink hues, gorgeous gold flooding the crevices as the shadows slowly get longer.

"It's gorgeous. I get what you mean, that sometimes things feel stifling." She adds. "I've been living at home and for so long I was

afraid of what came next. I didn't know what I wanted to do, and I let it kind of stop me in my tracks. But sometimes being in Eternia can feel so fucking exhausting I could just scream."

She feels like she's just at a different pace from the rest of the world, not behind exactly but not in rhythm with the rest of the people she knows. Adora always feels a step or two offbeat, a phrase off of what to say, a shade too honest or too guarded.

"It's brave to take time to know what you want to do, Adora. I don't know what I would have done if I didn't know what I wanted. I can't imagine how hard that is." She reaches out, placing a comforting hand on her shoulder. "I had a really shitty home life that I'd rather forget. I know a thing or two about feeling misfit."

Adora pulls up her knees so she can rest her head there, then places her hand on top of Catra's and pulls it so that she's holding it. "Thanks. I'm really glad I've met you." She can't bring herself to say that she's glad Catra married her brother.

Catra seems to have read that between the lines because she sighs softly and smiles warmly at her. "I'm glad too, Adora."

Later that night she finally opens her texts from Glimmer.

Adora, I thought you were visiting Adam?

Did you end up on a date??

Who is this girl?? Is she into you?? You look into her!!!

WAIT—IS THIS THE WIFE??

SHE'S HOT

BUT ADORA

THAT CAN NOT POSSIBLY BE A STRAIGHT WOMAN

She sighs and calls her best friend, making sure to lock the door for privacy. "What do you mean not straight?" She asks with a furrowed brow.

"Look at her Adora. She's wearing a carabiner on her belt loop and her nails are short. Plus, the way she has her hand wrapped around you? Gay as *fuck*." Glimmer sounds like a deflating balloon, not catching a breath as she runs through her reasons.

"How is the way she was touching me gay?" She hears Glimmer take in a huge breath. "Never mind. It doesn't even matter if she's not straight because she's married to *my brother*. Remember?" The reminder is an important one. Ever since they came back from watching the sunset Adora has felt like their outing had been too close to a date for her liking. Or rather, she liked it too much for it to be good for her.

Glimmer sighs. "That is a bit of a situation, isn't it?"

Adora shakes her head and starts pacing, stepping around Adam's dirty laundry. "There is no situation. Catra was being nice to me by showing me around town." She opened up to Catra by the end of the day but that doesn't mean anything. At least, not anything that could justify the way Adora's heart clenches at the thought of her.

"She's also smoking hot and you're into her." Glimmer says knowingly.

"It doesn't matter Glim. I just have to make it through this visit and then I can just forget about it." She's only known Catra for two days and it's a silly crush. It'll pass and this could be an embarrassing thing she tells them in a few years as a funny story.

"Adora. You're thinking of going to FP, you'll probably see Catra all the time if you're hanging out with Adam. Which you will because he's your twin brother." Glimmer is using her sensible voice, which is really unfair.

"I'll get over it before I move." Adora asserts. It feels like a lie before it even leaves her lips.

Adam returns the next morning, looking like he'd been run over by a bus. He drops his bag on the ground by the door and Adora can hear Catra's sigh from across the room.

"Adam, you know that's not where your shit goes." She says it in a tired way as if she's used to him ignoring her when she says it.

"But my sunny delight! I just got home aren't you *so* excited to see me?" He says teasingly.

Adam tries to go in for a hug and Catra dodges him with surprisingly fast reflexes. "Absolutely not, Grayskull." She sniffs. She must notice Adora's weird look. "He's in uniform, it's literally illegal for him to do public displays of affection." She explains.

Adora is pretty sure that is only for kisses and that they actually have to be *in public* for it to apply, but she doesn't say anything. "Did you get any sleep while you were there?"

Adam rolls his eyes and gives her a tired smile. "I slept while standing for a little bit." Adora can't tell if he's joking or not. "What were you two up to?"

"Catra made breakfast yesterday; it was really good. Then we went around town. I sent you a picture. Today, we mostly lounged. Did you see the picture?" She quickly went through what they'd been up to, feeling her palm sweat as she does. She's not sure why she feels nervous to tell her brother these things—she didn't do anything *wrong*.

"Nah, I haven't been able to look at my phone really." He then looks at Catra with a raised eyebrow and a smirk. "Catra *cooked*, huh?"

Catra rolls her eyes. "I do that on occasion." She says flippantly but she sends him a glare.

"News to *me*." Adam smiles and looks back at Adora. "What did she make?"

Adora eyes Catra, hoping she'll step in. Instead, she leans back and crosses her arms. Suddenly, Adora feels like she's taking a test she's bound to fail. "I don't remember the name." She admits. "But it was *so good*, Adam. It had a tortilla with some red sauce and runny eggs. Maybe onion too? In that sauce maybe?" She looks to Catra for approval.

She nods and smiles. "Yeah. *Huevos Rancheros*, hotshot."

Adam rolls his eyes. "Well, you'll have to come to visit more often, so Catra can cook."

Adora bites her lips, realizing now is as good a time as any to tell Adam about FYOS. "About that. You know how I've been applying to vet tech programs?"

"Yeah?" He gives her a quizzical look.

"I got into FYOS. I think I want to go." She's sure she wants to go to FYOS, but she doesn't want to say anything definitive until the financial aid packages come in.

Adam lifts Adora off the ground in a bear hug, laughing as he swings her about like she weighs nothing. "You're going to be so close! We can see each other all the time!" She crushes her and Adora holds him back just as tightly. The last two years have been hard being so far from her brother. "This is the best news ever! How long have you known?"

"A few weeks now, but I wanted to tell you in person." She smiles brightly as he sets her down.

"Congratulations, Adora." She snaps her head to look at the other woman. Catra's eyes are warm and her words are heartfelt. Adora feels that clench in her chest again and she knows her smile must look silly.

"Well, I'm beat. Are you planning on going to bed soon too?" Adam asks Adora. He gives her a stare like when they were kids, and she was meant to follow his lead.

"Yeah, I'm pretty tired." She looks over at Catra. "Goodnight, Catra."

"Night, Grayskull." She says softly . She then looks up at Adam. "Times two, I guess."

She expects Adam to kiss Catra or hug her but instead, he rolls his eyes and walks toward his room.

When he closes the door, he gives Adora a meaningful look. "You had a good time while I was gone?" He asks with intention, his eyes cutting to the side.

"Yeah? I mean I wish you had been here to hang out, but it was cool." She says nervously , eyes darting to the side.

"Good. I'm glad. You know you can tell me anything right?" He puts a hand on her shoulder. "I'd love you no matter what, okay Dr?"

"Okay?" Does he think she's being weird with Catra? Or is it just because she waited to tell him about FØ? She hates when Adam tries to be cryptic.

Adam searches her gaze, and she just gives him a confused look back, really unsure about what he is trying to get to. Usually, she understands Adam without words, but this time she's at a loss. He takes a step back and the expression clears from his face.

"Alright then. I am exhausted so I'm gonna shower and then sleep. You're more than welcome to go back out and hang with Catra if you

want, she usually watches some TV before bed in the living room." He informs her with a soft smile. He then goes to the bathroom, leaving Adora alone in the bedroom.

She can hear the muffled sound of the TV and she presses her hand against the door but thinks better of it. There's probably not a lot of good waiting for her sitting with Catra in the dark late at night.

She tiptoes out of the room in the morning, letting Adam keep snoring. She's finished lacing up her shoes when she hears scuffling in the kitchen. She slowly creeps into the kitchen, trying to be sneaky, but Catra's eyes find her immediately, widening as they look her over.

"Where are you going?" Catra asks, cof fee mug in hand.

"Out for a run." She needs to clear her thoughts and having Catra in such close quarters isn't helping her get her head on straight.

She thinks she feels Catra's eyes on her, but she must be imagining it. "You aren't going to get… *cold* wearing that?"

She looks down at her sports bra and her shorts. "Uh, no. I always wear these." She tugs on the shorts. "I get too sweaty if I wear anything with more coverage." Wearing long shorts or even a shirt feels incredibly overstimulating when she's on a run.

Catra definitely looks down at her shorts this time and then back up at Adora. "Alright, hotshot. Do you want to try Colombian hot chocolate when you come back?"

"What's that?" Given the breakfast the other day, Adora is just about willing to try anything Catra makes.

"Usually, a Christmas treat but shit is good year-round. It's different than anything you've tried before but I promise it's good." She says with a wide smile. "I picked up some stuff for it earlier."

"Okay , yeah." She agrees readily before slipping out of the kitchen, forcing herself to follow through with her run instead of spending the rest of the morning chatting with Catra.

She's glad when she hits her stride, focusing only on the way her shoes feel when it hits the pavement and figuring out the direction she wants to move in. Her whole body falls into a familiar cadence, and she feels her mind wander to the apartment she just left.

Adam will wake up soon, ready to relax and hang out with Adora. And Catra. *His wife*. She still hasn't wrapped her head around her brother being married, much less to Catra. She feels guilt swell in her gut as she thinks of how attracted she is to the brunette and how connected she feels to her.

Before she knows it, it's been an hour and she's drenched in sweat, no closer to resolving the disagreement between her head and heart.

When she goes inside, Adam and Catra are there, and they seem to be bickering about something. She toes into the room, wondering if she should go take another lap to give them some privacy.

Before she can do that, Adam spots her. "Hey , sis!"

She catches Catra staring at her, and it makes her glad she's already flushing from her run.

"Oh, fuck me." Her head snaps to Catra at the quiet exclamation and she notices for the first time the brunette is actually blushing. She clears her throat. "Grayskull, you're getting sweat all over my floor ."

Adora lets out a yelp as she looks down. "Oh yes ma'am, I mean— Catra."

Catra laughs as Adora scurries into Adam's bedroom, quickly making her way to the bathroom. She groans loudly when she thinks of how she accidentally called Catra *ma'am*. She isn't even sure what possessed her to do that. She's such a fucking dork, especially

in front of a pretty girl like her. *Adam's wife*. She reminds herself ruefully.

She's still embarrassed when she gets out of the shower and finds Adam and Catra hanging out in the living room.

"You alright there Adora?" Catra calls out, smirking slightly.

"Yeah, I'm fine." She stretches a bit. Her limbs are still tender from her long run. "Did you end up making the hot chocolate?"

She shakes her head. "I will in a second." Catra walks right up to her and touches one of her forearms. "So, you work out a lot?" She asks casually, but her eyes look anything but.

Adora kind of chokes on her own spit, her eyes flying to Adam, who sighs exasperatedly. "I have to talk to my *wife*. You know, marriage stuff." Adora's gut drops. He pulls Catra along and they head to the kitchen.

Adora can hear furious whispering that gets a little louder. She tries not to overhear but some of Catra's words slip through. "Her *arms,* Adam. I don't know how you expect me to not say anything! You could have spotted this problem a mile away!"

Adora looks down at her tank top. She doesn't think there's anything wrong with her arms? Did Catra think she was being disrespectful? Catra shows way more skin while walking around but she also actually lives there.

She fidgets with the fabric until the whispers die down and they come back.

She tries to think of something to ask about. "Can I see your wedding pictures?" Seeing Catra and Adam happy together while getting married will definitely help douse whatever feelings she has for her sister-in-law.

They both freeze. Adam runs a hand through his hair and Catra bites her lip. "Wedding pictures." She mutters under her breath, almost like a curse. "Um, we don't have them. *Yet*." She adds.

"Yeah!" Adam all but shouts. "Because the photographer hasn't gotten them back to us." He says cheerfully. "We will definitely send them along once we get them." He nods vigorously.

"So, you didn't have a real wedding, but you had a real wedding photographer?" She asks, puzzled. It seems really out of character from what she's seen of them.

"Yeah, you know the memories and all that. We wanted the pictures to be nice." Catra says but she's kind of glaring at Adam and then looking at Adora.

"Alright. Any candids then? You must have taken some on your phone." She insists. She doesn't even really want to see the pictures, but at this point, it feels weird not to follow through.

"They're on my laptop. But I do have a picture of what I wore." Catra scrolls through her phone and lands on a picture. "Here."

Adora's eyes widen as she looks at the photo. "You wore a *suit*"?

Adora can hear Adam raise his palm to his head and groan, although she can't imagine why.

"Yeah, I did. What? You into heteronormative looks, Adora?" She teases as she takes back the phone. It doesn't matter the image will be burned into Adora's retinas forever.

Adora shakes her head, eyes never leaving the picture. "No, it just" — *make Catra look so fucking hot* ~~"~~caught me by surprise. That's all."

Adam looks physically pained as he looks between them. "Okay, okay, you two can cut it out. You don't have to hide that you're

together.”Adam says with a roll of his eyes.

Adora stares at him like he grew a second head because well, why did he think she would betray him like that? I mean sure she had this massive crush on Catra but she’s doing her best to tamp it down and besides, Catra doesnt like Adora unless “Catra’s not straight?” Adora asks uncertainly.

Catra lets out a deep groan. “No, I am a *lesbian*. Thanks for finally telling your sister that this isn’t a real marriage, by the way.”She sends Adam an annoyed stare.

Adam’s eyes are wide as he looks between the women. “Wait, so you aren’t fucking?”

“Despite my best efforts, no,”Catra says a bit petulantly.

“Wait you”—Adora thinks of every casual touch between Catra and her, the teasing smirks, the genuine and honest conversations, and “oh fuck, you were hitting on me.”

Catra looks like she might break something. “I think you both split a brain in the womb, it’s the only way you’re this oblivious.”

“Can someone please explain what is going on?”Adora demands.

Adam sighs and looks at Catra. “So, Catra and I got married for the military benefits. I really wanted to get out of the barracks, the living conditions suck. The only way out is to get married, so you’re allowed to live off base.”

“And the military pays for me to go to FDU,”Catra says easily. “I couldn’t afford to go to the engineering program otherwise. So we basically decided to help each other out. *As friends*.”

“Then why couldn’t you just say that? I’ve been feeling like such an asshole having a crush on your *wife*!”Adora burst out. All of that

conflict could have been avoided if Adam had just said something to her.

Catra raises her eyebrow, an almost predatory look in her eyes. "Oh yeah, princess?"

Adam groans and covers his eyes with his hands. "Ew , no, no, no, do that on your own time. When my innocent ears and eyes do not have to witness it." He uncovers his eyes and looks at Adora pleadingly, scuffing his shoe on the floor. "I didnt say anything because the fewer people that know that it's fake the better. And I felt ashamed in a way, I didnt want my family to feel less of me."

Adora softens at that. "Adam, we wouldnt have thought less of you." She chastises lightly. "W e love you."

He waves her off. She can tell he's trying to avoid getting emotional, his lips puckered in a way that only happens when Adam is trying to keep tears from his eyes. "Point is, I thought Cat had told you our marriage was fake, and you were both seeing each other since you're clearly into it." He explains. He then gives Adora an exasperated stare. "Also, I cant believe you thought Catra was straight~~th~~at' s on you."

"That' s what I've *been* saying." Catra agrees with him.

She looks between them and realizes she isnt even sure that she' s seen them touch each other, never mind doing something romantic. "W ell, I feel like a dumbass."

"It' s okay, I'm apparently into that now ," Catra says with a smirk. She then sends Adam a look that screams for him to get out of the room.

"I'll let you two talk," Adam says and he goes to his room.

When they are alone, Adora looks up at Catra leaning against the couch and staring back. It feels like every movement is more charged now that Adora realizes this situation is so dif ferent from

what she'd thought. She walks closer to Catra than she' s dared before, placing a hand on the couch right next to her .

"Hey ," Adora says softly , leaning in close.

"Hey ." Catra is subdued, the earlier tease in her voice gone as she holds Adora's gaze.

Adora bites her lip as she looks at the brunette. "Why does this feel "—

"Awkward?" She of fers with a shy smile.

Adora nods. "Yeah."

"I don't know maybe there are things we should say to each other ." She says with a raised eyebrow, a flicker of her signature wit flickering through the mostly serious statement.

"You're beautiful." Adora breathes out. She isn't sure if that' s the most important thing she has to say to Catra but it definitely needs to be said. "And talking with you feels really easy . I like you. Romantically." Adora clarifies.

"I like you too." Catra smirks. "Even though you thought I was straight."

"That' s not what it was! It just never crossed my mind that it could be fake." She admits shyly . "I didn't think he'd lie about being married to you because I didn't think there was anyone who wouldn't fall for you. You're like no one I've ever met before."

Catra reaches up slowly, placing a soft kiss on her lips. "You're really sweet." She breathes the words into Adora, and she can feel Catra' s eyelashes fluttering against her cheek.

Adora leans down to capture her lips more fully, wrapping one arm around her waist and tugging her up so that she was sitting on the

arm of the couch. She feels her knees go weak as she feels Catra moan. Her hands start to wander when she hears a sharp whistle.

"I'm glad y'all like each other and all but no making out in the living room. New rule." Adam groans holding a glass of water . "This is going to be worse than when you were dating Sarah junior year . I didn't sleep for like half a semester ." He grumbles as he walks toward the room. Adora hears a distinct click as he turns the lock.

"Looks like you're staying with me tonight, princess," Catra says as she runs her hands through Adora's hair.

Adora presses her forehead against Catra's. She thinks about how in a few short months they'll be living in the same town and really , there isn't anything stopping them from exploring whatever lies between them. "Sounds like a plan."

End Notes

This is entirely based on a prompt given to me by Static, thanks for the way you support my writing and for your friendship :)

If y'all are interested I kind of want to write a Catra POV on this, it would mostly be 1) how did Adam and Catra agree to get married 2) their shenanigans and banter behind the scenes 3) a quasi-epilogue where Catra meets Marlena as Adora's girlfriend. Thoughts? Let me know!

As always, kudos and comments make me really happy. You can follow me on Twitter @resFlower1 to see snippets of the like 10 other one-shots I'm working on right now lol

With this fic, I have posted over 400k words on AO3 which feels like a big achievement. Thanks for supporting my writing :)

Please drop by the archive and comment to let the author know if you enjoyed their work!